



Addressing his allies

President Thieu addresses 7,000 American troops and a crowd of journalists during a visit from US President Lyndon Johnson to Cam Ranh Bay in October 1966. A major US Navy base, Cam Ranh Bay also had a large Air Force base and a substantial US Army presence.

Standing alone

Thieu eventually signed the 1973 Peace Accords, on the basis that the US would continue to supply aid and air support. When US support diminished, Thieu publicly accused Henry Kissinger of tricking him into signing the agreement.

With the US out of the war, Thieu and the ARVN were left to fight the North Vietnamese Army (NVA) alone. During the final NVA offensive in 1975, Thieu and his army were proved inadequate by the communist forces, which soon closed in on Saigon. Time and again, Thieu expressed his bitterness over being left to fight alone by his former allies.

Thieu realized that he would not emerge victorious. On April 21, 1975, he made an emotional final speech to South Vietnam, and resigned as president, leaving the task of surrendering Saigon to his successor. Five days later, he flew out of Vietnam, and eventually moved to the US. He lived a quiet life in Foxboro, Massachusetts, until his death in 2001.